

WHAT IS A SOUL?

People describe the soul as the “me” inside a human body. All of the things that make people who they are—personality, feelings, ideas, emotions, intelligence, and a sense of self—come from the soul. This is what gives a person being and purpose. While the body will eventually die, many believe that the soul can live on, immortal and indestructible. In philosophy, the belief in a nonphysical soul separate from the physical human body is called dualism. Do you have a little soul inside you? Let’s move on to life’s dance floor . . .

WELCOME TO SOUL NIGHT

LIFE AND SOUL

Most soul supporters agree that living humans have individual souls. You get one when you are born and give it up when you die—but that’s not the sole belief. Others think that the soul inside a person is part of one universal soul. Many believe that animals have souls, and others think inanimate objects, such as rivers, the wind, blades of grass, and the Sun, have a soul, although the human soul is the most complex of all.

“BE CARELESS IN YOUR DRESS IF YOU MUST, BUT KEEP A TIDY SOUL.”

Mark Twain (1835–1910),
American author

SOUL-SEARCHING

Many philosophers have done a lot of soul-searching on this issue. Plato (c. 427–347 BCE), for example, thought there were three souls: a sensible thinking one in your head, a spirited emotional one in your chest, and a hungry thrill-seeking one in your abdomen. He believed they worked together as one to shape a person’s actions and behavior. In the traditional religion of the Fiji people, the soul is a mini person, too small to be visible but an exact copy. In some cultures, people think the soul can exist outside the body.